C7W4 · THURSDAY, FEBRUARY 12, 2026

DEFINE YOUR TARGET AUDIENCE

From Interview Data to a Clear Customer Profile

HOW DID INTERVIEWS GO?

- Show of hands: who got to **5+ interviews**?
- Who got to **8+**?
- What was the **hardest part**?

> 💡 If you're short on interviews, finish this weekend. The quality of next week depends on it.

QUICK LOGISTICS

Risk, liability, and team contracts

RISK & LIABILITY

As your products reach real users, we need guardrails.

STILL BANNED

- Medical / health diagnosis
- Financial advice / transactions
- Anything involving minors
- Legal advice

YOUR GUARDRAILS

- Hard cap: **1,000 users**
- No sensitive data collection
- Be transparent: "student project"
- Problems → tell Ken immediately

⚠️ Without an LLC, team members can be **personally liable**. These guardrails protect everyone.

THE 1,000 USER CAP

10	100	~1,000
FOR INTERVIEWS	FOR LANDING PAGE	SCALE TARGET
This week	Weeks 5-6	End of course

1,000 users is enough to prove product-market fit. Beyond 1,000 → come talk to me.

TEAM CONTRACTS

Set expectations now — before things get intense.

- What's expected of each member (hours, communication, deliverables)
- How decisions get made
- What happens if someone stops contributing
- What happens with IP after the course
- What happens if the team splits

📝 **Action:** Fill this out with your team this week. Template will be shared after class.

FROM INTERVIEWS TO AUDIENCE

Synthesizing what you heard

THE 3-OF-5 RULE

You did **5** interviews per problem space.

Did **3 of 5** describe the same problem the same way?

Yes → you have signal. No → narrow your customer segment.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

STRONG SIGNAL

- Multiple people describe the **same pain** unprompted
- **Emotional language** — cursing, frustration, detailed rants
- They've **spent money** trying to solve it
- **Excited reaction** to your solution pitch
- Offered **referrals** or follow-ups

WEAK SIGNAL

- Only agree when **you describe** the problem
- "Kind of annoying" + **shrug**
- **Never tried** to solve it
- "That's interesting" + **polite nod** to your pitch
- No one offered a **referral**

The problem space with stronger signal across these dimensions is your winner.

TEAM PRESENTATIONS

2-3 min per team · Until 2:00

PRESENTATION FORMAT

Each team shares (2-3 min):

1. **TWO PROBLEM SPACES**
   What did you explore?
2. **INTERVIEW COUNT**
   How many per space?
3. **PATTERNS & SURPRISES**
   What emerged? What surprised you?
4. **STRONGEST SIGNAL**
   Best quote or reaction?
5. **YOUR LEAN**
   Which space are you leaning toward?

LISTENING GUIDE

While other teams present, listen for:

- Is the problem described in **user language** (not team language)?
- Is there **emotional intensity**, or just rational agreement?
- Did anyone mention **spending money** on the problem?
- Are there **clear personas** emerging, or is the audience too broad?

> 💡 Best feedback isn't "that's cool" — it's "have you considered..." or "I noticed you didn't mention..."
> **Apply the Mom Test to each other.**

DEFINE YOUR AUDIENCE

Team work · Until 2:15

THREE TASKS (15 MIN)

1. GO/NO-GO (3 MIN)

Which problem space had stronger signal?
If both were strong → which does the team prefer?
If neither → plan more interviews this weekend
Lock in ONE concept.

2. AUDIENCE DEFINITION (7 MIN)

Fill out the template on the next slide using **exact language from interviews**.
Not "busy professionals" → "Columbia grad students who spend $50+/week on Seamless"

3. PREP FOR NEXT WEEK (5 MIN)

Top 3 quotes from interviews that could become landing page copy.
Plus: one sentence describing your solution

AUDIENCE DEFINITION TEMPLATE

FIELD	FILL IN
Who are they?	Demographics: age, occupation, location
What do they care about?	Values, goals, frustrations
Where do they hang out?	Online communities, physical spaces, channels
How do they describe the problem?	Exact phrases from interviews
What have they tried?	Current solutions and shortcomings
What would make them switch?	Must-have features or experiences

⚠️ Use the **EXACT words** from your interviews. Your interviewees' language is your landing page copy next week.

NEXT WEEK

WEEK 5: SOLUTION VALIDATION

1

GENERATE BRAND POSITIONS

Use AI to create 3-4 positioning options from your interview language

2

TEST WITH SYNTHETIC USERS

Build personas from real interview data, run 50 iterations per persona

3

BUILD LANDING PAGE

Use the winning position to create your vaporware site

🎯 Everything next week depends on the quality of your interviews. If you're short — **finish this weekend**.

THE VALIDATION PIPELINE

WEEK	WHAT HAPPENS	STATUS
Week 4	Interviews → audience definition	**This week**
Week 5	Brand positions → synthetic pre-flight → landing page	Next
Week 6	Drive traffic → collect signups → analyze demand	Coming
Week 7+	Build the real product	Coming

✅ Problem → Solution → Demand → Build. You're completing Step 1 today.

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

- **Finish interviews** this weekend if you're short of 8
- **Team contract:** fill out with your team this week
- **Stuck on go/no-go?** Come to office hours
- **Next Tuesday:** Bring your audience definition + top interview quotes

📋 **Continue reading:** *The Mom Test* if not finished

QUESTIONS?

END OF CLASS 7

Next: Solution Validation